STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 13 · The Problem Inside

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Good to see you sitting down. Uh, I got here a little early. Room was already quiet. So I stood in the back and nodded at a man who wasn't there. Yeah. I will manage a doorway before I will start a true thing. Some of you, you know, ran a cousin of that out where the cars are. One more song. One more text that could've waited. Then you came in. I'm glad. Last time we talked about not doing this alone. A man you could call if you went down. A man out ahead, if you'd ask him. Some of you asked. Some of you, uh, still have the name and not the talk. I'm not— I'm not gonna walk that road again. You can have a good man in your corner and still wreck the next room you enter. You can leave a hard house and set the same man down in a kinder kitchen. That's what we're on. The problem inside. If you're new, I'm Wes. You're in the right chair. Now listen. A man can tell a true story about what was done to him. I want that story told where it belongs. He can still be hiding what he himself did before breakfast. Both can be true. Only one of them is his to hand to God.

One sentence gives us four marks for what a real man is. I have not improved them. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. You've heard them in this room. I'm not gonna tour the list. Today they stand over what's in you. Not over the old story alone. Uh, passivity, today, is a soft word where a true one belongs. Responsibility is a sentence that can end without a second author. Courage is letting another man hear it while your face is still hot. And God's pay is not the relief of never being the problem. His pay is a man made new. Here's the claim. The trouble is not only what was done to you. The trouble is in you. It's in me. It has a name. The name has a cure. And the cure has already been paid for. If I only soak the wound, you leave with sympathy and a full alibi. I won't do that to you. I mean, the wound can be real. We'll say that plain. It still does not get to write the rest of your days.

You can change the house. You can change the street. You cannot drop yourself off at the last place and drive away clean. I know the speech. If they had been better, I would be better. Some of that is true. It is not the whole wound. Uh, let me tell on myself. A while back I got home late. Not a crisis. I just didn't want the kitchen. The noise. The questions. The ordinary ask of being a husband. So I rode around. I told my wife I was finishing something. I wasn't. When it came up later, I had a softer line ready. I said, I haven't been my best. That sentence was true and it was a cover. Haven't been my best can mean anything. It let me skip the part where I chose a lie so I could stay out. The day was long. The day did not pick the route. I did. You know, I wanted the old story to carry that hour. My people. My pace. My tired. Some of those are real. None of them sent the text that said I was still working. Stay with that. You cannot repent of another man's

sin. You can repent of yours. That is not a harsher life. That is the first thing God actually has in His hands.

Now, don't hear a trick. I'm not saying a hard house did nothing. It did. Some of you are still bleeding from a man who should've stayed and didn't. I will not talk over that. Hear the other half. Say the house had been steady. Say he knew your name and used it kindly. Say he came back when he said he would. I still would not hand you a clean heart at the end of that story. Something in a man leans the wrong way even in a kind room. Uh, I learned that in my own kitchen, on a Saturday that was fine. My boy mouthed off. Not a crime. A boy, tired, testing the edge. I corrected him at a volume that was about me. Somebody from the street could've heard. I didn't want to be the man who couldn't hold a Saturday. Later I told myself I just care about respect. Respect was not the volume. Embarrassment was. My wife didn't pile on. She looked at me. She didn't have to build a case. I already knew the sentence. I sinned. I used my son's ear to settle my pride. A calmer childhood would not have pulled that volume out of my mouth. The volume was mine. You can be handed a hard pattern. You are still the one who runs it today.

Paul tells on a man who loves God and still finds a law in himself that will not obey. He is not performing despair. He is telling the truth. Romans seven, verse eighteen. For I know that good itself does not dwell in me, that is, in my sinful nature. For I have the desire to do what is good, but I cannot carry it out. Desire is not delivery. A clean intention is not a clean heart. Uh, you can want to be a gentle man at supper and still hear your own voice cut. You can want the true sentence and feel the smoother one win. I have wanted the right thing and watched my feet go the other way. You know that split. It is not rare in this room. And it is not the proof that you don't love God. Paul loved God and wrote the split down. Here's where men get fooled. They think more wanting will finish the job. Or more managing. A cleaner schedule. A stricter morning. I mean, those can be good. They are not new metal in a man. They are coaching. You can be coached into looking fine. Looking fine is a surface. You need to be made new. Hold the verse one more time, because it's kinder than it sounds. He has the desire. He cannot carry it out. That honesty is where God starts. Not where He shames a man for wanting good and missing it.

The word is sin. Men dodge it two ways. Some reach for a softer word, because sin sounds too hard for a decent life. Uh, I had a whole set. I'm in a season. I'm working on my tone. I haven't been my best. I told a man I was in process. He said, toward what. A struggle is something that happens to you. A sin is something you do. You manage a struggle. You repent of a sin. Soft words keep the room polite. They also keep the real thing employed. Other men dodge it because somebody swung that word when they were boys. Loud. To win. You got small, and you decided you would never let that word near you again. I am not here to borrow his volume. When God says sin, He is naming a sickness, not beating a child. A true name is how a sick man finds the doctor. So here is the job. Say it about yourself. Out loud. To God. Specific. I sinned. I blank. Not, I struggle with. The act has to be in the sentence. If the sentence could fit any man,

it isn't yours yet. A younger guy in our circle, I'll call him Barry. Sharp mouth with his friends. He said he got it honest. His dad talked that way, so the cut wasn't really his. He texted me later. I sinned. I cut those men down at the table, and I liked the laugh. The laugh was mine. That's the sentence. No costume on it.

How many of you have a softer word ready for something you did? Go on. I'm not collecting them. Yeah. That's most of us. I carried one for years and called it humility. Keep two things apart, or the second one will steal the confession. Guilt says, I did a wrong thing. Shame says, I am a wrong thing. Guilt can be spoken. Then it can sit down. Shame will not sit. It keeps a man up, and it sends him back to whatever quiets the noise. The old cover was built for that feeling. If you only feel bad, shame is still running the hour. I once apologized to a door I had shut too hard. The door forgave me immediately. The people on the other side were not a door. Feeling sorry is cheap when nothing in you turns. A man can ache about a thing for a long time and keep his feet pointed the same direction. That ache is not repentance. Repentance is the feet. You say it. You repair what can be repaired. You make the easy repeat harder next time. You go back to your work. And when you miss, you turn again. That is not a failed life. That is a Christian one, from the inside. A man keeps coming back to the Father he keeps leaving. And the Father keeps taking him in.

Let me show you the but. I have worn it. Uh, I got short with my wife on a morning that was already tight. Kids, clocks, a tone from me that didn't need to be there. I came back with a sorry that looked like a sorry. I'm sorry I got short, but you know how that morning went. The but ate it. I had hired her as the second author of my sin. She didn't need the essay. She needed the period. I had to go back. Same kitchen. Smaller voice. I sinned. I took a tight morning and I spent it on you. No because. You know, my mouth hated that. It wanted the context. Context can be true and still be a hiding place. If her name is the last word of your confession, you have not confessed. You have filed a complaint. Married men, she is not the problem on this page. I don't know your whole house. I know this. If the only sentence you can build starts with her, you are still outside the work. Same if the last word is your boss, your dad, or the pressure. Pressure is real. Pressure did not choose the cruel line. You did. Say the sentence until it can stand without a crutch. Then, and only then, you may tell the rest of the truth about what was hard. The order matters.

A man I stood with, I'll call him Owen. His boy and mine ended up on the same field for a stretch of Saturdays. We weren't close at first. We just both stayed after the other dads left, picking up water bottles like it was a job. Owen could talk about his father without raising his voice. The man had been cruel. Not a cartoon. A real chronic meanness about what Owen cost him. I believe Owen. The story held. He had a patient wife and a decent little house, and from the outside he had gotten out. What he would not say was in a note on his phone. Lines about her. A cabinet left open. A tone she used when she was tired. He called it memory, so he wouldn't get spun. One Saturday he read me three lines, quiet, like he was explaining the marriage. I heard a

man building a file. I said, Owen, that note isn't helping you remember. It's helping you win. He told me not to say it like that. We finished the bottles. We didn't fix it there. A few days on, he called. He said, I need a sentence, and I need you not to tidy it. I sinned. I have been collecting her faults so I would never have to look at mine. He thought I'd be done with him. I asked what he was gonna do next. Delete the note. Tell her he had kept it. And ask one man to ask him if the note came back. I prayed. He didn't need my speech. He told me later the hard part was his own voice saying I sinned with no because on the end. He slept. The next disagreement was shorter. He didn't have a list.

If I stopped there, you'd leave heavier, and I would have failed you. The name without the cure is just a brighter despair. Don't do that with this. First John one, verses eight and nine. If we claim to be without sin, we deceive ourselves and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness. Faithful. Just. Forgive. Purify. Not, coach him until the outside looks managed. Purify. That is inside work. Titus three, verse five. He saved us, not because of righteous things we had done, but because of his mercy. He saved us through the washing of rebirth and renewal by the Holy Spirit. Not because you finally sounded honest. Because of His mercy. Rebirth. Renewal. You are not being asked to decorate a man. You are being made new. Uh, the cure was paid before your sentence got brave. He did not wait until your story was tidy. He knew what was in you and He carried it anyway. So when you say I sinned, you are not informing God. You are agreeing with Him. And agreement is where the mercy lands. Proverbs twenty-eight, verse thirteen. Whoever conceals their sins does not prosper, but the one who confesses and renounces them finds mercy. Conceal. Or confess and renounce. Those are the two roads. Only one of them has mercy on it.

Let me walk the room. Young men. You are not only your dad. If the sharp sentence came out of your mouth, it is also you. You can tell the truth about the house you learned it in and still own the cut you made. Honor what was hard. Don't hide inside it. If you're single, do not make a woman you have not met into your priest. God can hear you today. A brother can hear you today. You do not need a wedding to tell the truth. If you're married, I said it, and I'll say it once more. She is not the assignment. This page is yours. If the house got quiet, if the papers are signed, I will not stand up here and total the whole wreck as yours. God saw every mile. So did the two of you. Your part is still yours. It has to be allowed to finish. I did this. Period. If her name is glued on the end, that is a different speech. If you were wounded, hear this slow. Naming what is inside you does not make the wound fake. It happened. Naming your sin keeps his sin from becoming your alibi for the rest of a life. Older men. Some of you can tell the old story with real skill. It is polished. It is mostly true. If I asked what you did yesterday that needs the word sin, the account gets thin. A long story about him and a short story about you is still a place to hide.

And if the work is going well, don't take a bow in this part. They trust you. The meeting. The crew. The hard call. Trusted is not the same as well. A clean record at work can sit on top of a

man who hasn't told the truth in his own house in a long time. Uh, competence is a gift. It is not righteousness. So here is what you do with it. Not a program. A sentence, and then a habit of sentences. Before you sleep, name that day's sins by name. Out loud. To God. I sinned. I blank. Then thank Him. In Christ, the forgiveness is already yours. You are not paying it off with the naming. You are agreeing with a mercy that got there first. Watch what shame tries to do with the quiet after. It will want the last word. I am the wrong thing. Don't hand it that. Guilt told the truth. Shame is a liar on a true stage. And tell a brother one of them. To his face, or on the phone. Not a hint. The sentence. Tell him what you're gonna do next. Then let him pray. You don't need a perfect circle before you open your mouth. Sin does not wait until your friendships feel impressive. How many of you can already feel the sentence, and it still wants a because on the end? Hands. Be honest. Yeah. Leave the because in the chair when you go to the table.

Let me land this. The problem is in you. Not only in what was done to you. The wound can be real and still not be the author. Desire is not delivery. A soft word will keep the surface polite and keep the sin employed. Say, I sinned, and put the act in it. Not, I struggle with. Guilt tells the truth and then it can sit. Shame lies, and it will send you back to the cover. Turn. Repair what you can. Tell a brother. And remember the cure was paid before you were brave. What I hope you walk out with is one sentence you stopped decorating, and a Father who already knew it and stayed. Your workbook is where it gets particular. In a minute you'll sit at the tables and work this part together. Get the questions in your ear. Say it. I sinned. I blank. Not, I struggle with. What soft word have you been using on it? And who is gonna hear one of them? Before you sleep, name the day's sins by name. Thank Him that forgiveness is already yours in Christ. Notice what shame does when the room gets quiet. Tell a brother one. What you'll do next. Let him pray. Carry this, and write it where you'll see it. The problem inside has a name. The name has a cure. The cure has been paid for. The marks still stand. You've carried one sentence through this room. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Today the passive thing is the soft word. Say the true one. Tables are yours. Work this part of the workbook together. I'm not going far.